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Brand Management Through Narrowing the Gap Between Brand Identity and Brand Reputation

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Classical models of brand management pay insufficient attention to staff as brand builders, placing more emphasis on external issues such as image. This paper explores the significant contribution from employees and considers the need to align their values and behaviours with the brand's desired values. It clarifies the importance of culture in brand building and discusses how an adaptive, strategically appropriate culture, consistently apparent throughout an organisation is likely to be associated with healthy brand performance. A model is proposed, suggesting that stronger brands result from a homogeneous brand identity, with congruent identity components. It argues that reputation is a more appropriate external assessment of a brand than image. By auditing the gaps between brand identity and brand reputation, managers can identify strategies to minimize incongruency and develop more powerful brands. It is concluded that brand reality is an important aspect of branding.

Introduction

Since the 1980s, when firms awoke to the financial value of brands (Murphy 1992), branding has attracted considerable interest amongst both researchers (e.g. Shocker, Srivastava and Ruekert 1994) and consultants/practitioners (eg Macrae 1996a). Much has been written about the interaction between brands and consumers (e.g. Cowley 1991; Keller 1998) with less about the role of organisations' staff (eg Kapferer 1997; Aaker 1996). A similar bias to researching customer rather than organisational issues has occurred in marketing (Ruekert and Walker 1987). The research emphasis needs rebalancing, addressing the role of staff in brand building (eg Ambler and Barrow 1996; Balmer 1995), particularly since in the new information age technology is automating far more

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processes, leaving the more judgmental, value based decisions to staff.

There are several reasons for looking inside an organisation when brand building.

One reason can be appreciated from considering a brand's key components and the move from individual line branding to corporate branding. As researchers have shown (eg de Chernatony 1993; Bhat and Reddy 1998), at the broadest brands satisfy functional and emotional needs. To dominate attractive positionings, managers strive to incorporate a unique mix of functional and emotional values into their brand. Functional values are more difficult to sustain due to factors such as advances in technology (Lambin 1996), similar designs for competing brands (de Chernatony and McDonald 1998) and the ease of copying competitors' prices (Balmer and Stotvig 1997). Consequently much branding activity has focused on building emotional values (Goodyear 1996). These evolve not just from advertising, but also from the firm's staff interacting with different stakeholder groups. Increasingly organisations are linking their brands with their corporate values, putting more emphasis on corporate rather than line brand building (King 1991; Mitchell 1994). Insufficient attention to communicating to staff the corporation's values and their individual roles in delivering them, can result in inconsistencies between the brand's espoused values in the media and the values perceived when dealing with staff.

In developed economies dominated by service (Zeithaml and Bitner 1996), quality control is shifting from factory production lines to the joint production and consumption of services brands between staff and consumers. Staff play a significant role in services branding, as the turn around of ASDA demonstrated (Norman 1997). Their assumptions, attitudes, beliefs and values influence consumers' brand perceptions. However, different departments may have differing values from the sub-cultures of the firm (Brown 1995) and through a lack of alignment, inconsistent perceptions may result as consumers come in contact with different parts of the organisation.

Another reason for looking inside the organisation is the shift in the branding literature from the importance of image (Boulding 1956), focusing on consumers' perceptions of brand differentiation, to identity (Kapferer 1997) which is more concerned with how managers and staff make brands unique. An important component of a brand's identity is the organisation's culture, which influences the corporate brand's values. This is perceived through the metaphor of the corporate personality (Abratt 1989, Olins 1995). There is a growing literature on corporate identity (eg Marwick and Fill 1997; Hatch and Schultz 1997; Balmer and Stotvig 1997; Morison 1997; Wilson 1997; Balmer 1995). This is moving away from just stressing graphic design and is focusing on integrating the values of an organisation with its unique logo, signaling desired behaviour to staff, and helping to align their values with the desired brand values.

Internally, managers face the challenges of defining the brand's values, then working across the organisation to ensure commitment, enthusiasm and consistent staff behaviour delivering these values. One of the external challenges is engendering confidence amongst multiple stakeholders about their brand's

ability to consistently deliver valued outcomes. This goes beyond focusing on brand image, which concerns the latest perceptions and continually changes. Instead, managers need to focus on reputations, which are more stable, representing the distillation of multiple images over time (Fombrun and Van Riel 1997).

This paper therefore predominantly explores issues internal to the organisation, and clarifies the significance to brand building of culture, staff alignment, and brand identity. It then looks externally at the importance of reputation and concludes by considering how brand management can be conceived as minimizing the gap between the brand's identity and its reputation.

Looking Inside the Organisation when Brand Building

Move to Corporate Branding

Writers (e.g. Olins 1995; Kapferer 1997; Laforet and Saunders 1994) have presented brand naming architectures showing varying strengths of association between line brands and their corporations. For a variety of reasons there is a move towards corporate branding (Mitchell 1994; Balmer 1995). Some might consider the reason for this as being due to the increasing costs of promoting individual line brands, or due to the advent of category management, where priority is given to promoting product sectors to retailers, rather than individual line brands. Mitchell (1997) provides a more complete picture. We have moved from the industrial age, which stressed tangible assets, to the information age which seeks to exploit intangibles such as ideas, knowledge and information. The new branding model is therefore one which emphasizes value through employees' involvement in relationship building. Internally brand management is becoming culture management and externally it is customer interface management. In the new branding mode corporate branding internally signals messages about the desired culture and externally it reduces the information overload problems from line branding, decreasing customers' information processing costs. Corporate branding facilitates consumers' desires to look deeper into the brand and assess the nature of the corporation. A further reason for corporate branding is that through building respect and trust with one of the corporation's offerings, consumers are more likely to accept the corporation's promises about other offerings.

Corporate branding thus provides the strategic focus for a clear positioning, facilitates greater cohesion in communication programmes (Siegel 1994), enables staff to better understand the type of organisation they work for, and thus provides inspiration about desired styles of behaviour (Smythe, Dorward and Reback 1992).

Managing corporate brands needs a different approach to classic line branding. Individual line branding primarily focuses on consumers and distributors and few staff interact with consumers. By contrast, corporate branding is about multiple stakeholders interacting with many staff from numerous departments and important objectives are ensuring a consistent

message and uniform delivery across all stakeholder groups (King 1991). In line branding, consumers mainly assess the brand's values from advertising, packaging, distribution and the people using the brand. Yet in corporate branding, while values are partly inferred from corporate communication campaigns, stakeholders' interactions with staff are also important.

In the early days of some corporate brands (e.g. Virgin, Body Shop and Hewlett Packard) strong personality entrepreneurs had a philosophy about their brand making the world a better place (Collins and Porras 1996) and recruited staff with similar values to theirs (Buchanan and Hurczynski 1997). With a low number of staff in regular contact, stakeholders were likely to perceive a consistent corporate brand. Success resulted in growth and more staff. The more successful firms communicated their brand philosophy through a culture that rigidly enshrined particular core values, allowing peripheral values and practices to adapt over time. New staff could appreciate from the culture how to contribute as brand builders. In less successful corporations, new managers were uncomfortable with the issues of corporate culture and brand visions and over time lost sense of their core values (Kotter and Heskett 1992). New staff were less confident about the corporation's core values and different styles of behaviour evolved, causing disparate perceptions amongst stakeholders.

In corporate branding, staff are not only critical contributors to the brand's values, but represent evaluative brand cues (Hansen 1972). As such, the HRM Director should be a key member of the brand's team, since they devise policy on brand building issues such as recruitment, induction and training. At Waterstone's, the Marketing Director's view is "Recruitment is a branding exercise, it's part of the management of the corporate brand" (Ind 1998, p325). The need for more emphasis on staff as brand builders is echoed by others. For example, Mottram (1998) argues that staff must understand the brand's vision, be totally committed to delivering it, and more emphasis should be placed on internal communication (eg. Intranets).

These points indicate that corporations need to pay more attention to their cultures, since these encompass their staff's values and assumptions which affect their behaviour and thus influence stakeholders' perceptions, as is next considered.

Integration Paradigm of Corporate Culture

Researchers (e.g. Parasuraman and Deshpande 1984; Wilkins and Ouchi 1983) have exhorted the need for more attention to corporate culture. Until the relatively recent interest in corporate identity and reputation, culture had attracted little attention in marketing (Deshpande and Webster 1989). In part this may be due to this concept's complex nature (Ogbonna and Harris 1998), which has given rise to over 160 definitions (Kroeber and Kluckhohn 1952).

Interpretations of "culture" can be divided into two main groups (Semircich 1983). The first group of writers, who have dominated culture research, adopted a positivistic perspective, conceptualizing it as something an organisation "has". Deshpande and Webster's (1989) definition is a good example, i.e. "Culture is a

set of shared assumptions and understandings about organizational functioning" (p5). This school regards culture as an independent variable, for example imported into a firm when staff join, or as a by-product of the firm's production. It emphasizes homogeneity from a unified, collective consensus of the organisation, with senior managers instrumental in defining their organisation's culture and directing staff to accept and adhere to it (Legge 1995). Some refer to this as the integration paradigm (Meyerson and Martin 1987).

Schein (1984) is a key proponent of this school of thought. His definition has many attractions from a corporate branding perspective, i.e. "The pattern of basic assumptions that a given group has invented, discovered, or developed in learning to cope with its problems of external adaptations and internal integration and that have worked well enough to be considered valid and, therefore, to be taught to new members as the correct way to perceive, think and feel in relation to those problems" (p6). This helps brand managers analyze their culture at three levels and identify corrective action. The first level, visible artifacts, is instantly recognizable and easiest to change. It is the most superficial manifestation of the corporate culture and includes aspects such as the building's architecture, office designs, staff's dress style, their behaviour and logos. These are visible clues about an organisation's brands and management needs to regularly audit these to ensure they all communicate the same message. If employees' styles of behaviour are inconsistent with the desired brand identity, to understand "why", the next level needs investigating, i.e. their values. Many instruments have been developed to measure organisational culture at this level (see Cooke and Szumal 1993), however, directed interviewing is likely to reveal post-hoc rationalizations for behaviour, or ideal values. It is therefore necessary to delve to the third level of culture, appreciating unconscious underlying assumptions; i.e. the learned responses that started as espoused values which, through experience, are reinforced and become taken for granted assumptions.

Advances in means-end theory (Gutman 1982) enabled researchers to use laddering techniques (Reynolds and Gutman 1988) to elicit hierarchical maps, showing how people relate brand attributes to their values, and has become popular for exploring values amongst both managers (Jenkins 1996) and consumers (Reynolds, Gengler and Howard 1995). However laddering techniques do not tap into unconscious underlying basic assumptions. Employing ethnographic research methods (Gill and Johnson 1991; Hirschman 1986), researchers can explore the five types of basic assumptions Schein (1984) suggested, i.e. (i) the firm's relationship with its environment, (ii) its view about establishing 'truth' and decision making, (iii) the firm's view about human nature, (iv) assumptions about what is right for staff to do and (v) the way staff should relate to each other. From an analysis of the five types of basic assumptions managers can then:

- assess whether there is coherence between them;
- predict the values that should be associated with these assumptions, then after measuring these values identify which issues need greater

consideration;

- consider whether in the current commercial climate these basic assumptions hold true.

For example, analyzing the five basic assumptions of Philips Electronics shows why its performance has been poor. Philips' relationship with its environment, assumption (i), was that of staff focusing on technological leadership at the expense of customer orientation. This reinforced assumption (ii) that the nature of truth be vested in rational, technological considerations, rather than addressing consumers' decision criteria. Assumption (iii) resulted in staff who were good, capable corporate citizens deserving the continuing tradition of paternalism. Some argued this delayed decisions about redundancies when profitability fell. The nature of human activity, assumption (iv), was such that senior managers who had historically been successful, shunned different ways of doing business as the environment became harsher. Finally, from assumption (v), there was a prevalent belief in the independence of different sub-organisations, enabling Japanese competitors to take advantage of fragmented and uncoordinated actions.

Thus Schein's (1984) definition offers opportunities for better employing branding resources if managers:

- audit all three domains (artifacts, values and basic assumptions);
- explore the extent to which there is congruence between these three;
- assess gaps between the desired brand values and the three components of culture.

Differentiation Paradigm of Corporate Culture

The integration paradigm is conceptually appealing since having a shared set of values and basic assumptions reflects employees' needs for order and consistency. Staff reflect on the perceived culture to help them decide how to respond in a new, ambiguous situation (Wilkins and Ouchi 1983). However, this implies a culture split between corporate level and departmental level (Gregory 1983) and there is evidence that organisations are characterized by several cultures (Hofstede 1998), raising questions about whether shared values and assumptions should be considered more in terms of frequency, similarity, or intensity (Gordon and DiTomaso 1992). This second school of thought considers culture as a root metaphor for the organisation, i.e. a metaphor for organisational knowledge, or shared symbols and meanings, or the unconscious mind. Culture exists in and through social interactions of staff, negotiating and sharing symbols and meaning. The integration paradigm regards culture as something an organisation "has", while the metaphor perspective sees culture as something a group of people "are". The artifacts are no longer the visible layer of culture, rather the means of its transmission and negotiation (Morgan 1986). This interpretation recognizes that all firms have subcultures, which individually share similar values and assumptions, but the extent to which these conform to the

culture of senior management will vary.

Within the metaphor perspective, referred to as the differentiation paradigm (Meyerson and Martin 1987), culture is not a mechanism for management to change staff's values, assumptions and behaviour, but rather is a factor managers need to be attentive to. Some corporate brands have historically performed poorly (e.g. British Rail) as the culture espoused by senior managers in meetings ran contrary to employees' views and were not internalized within the diverse units. The implications for corporate brand management are that the subcultures need understanding and the diversity in values and assumptions need explaining to the senior team and all staff. Before assuming the problem is solely one of communication about the corporation's espoused culture, checks are needed (Martin 1992) to assess:

- Is there action inconsistency? For example, a Director continually talks about the importance of customers, yet when presented with a recommendation to change their brand to reduce customer complaints, rejects this due to the cost of production retooling.
- Is there symbolic inconsistency? For example, staff continually hear about "striving to achieve the highest quality", yet the carpeting in the offices looks worn out.
- Is there ideological inconsistency? For example, a financial institution proclaims its policy of ethical investments, but then accepts an invitation from a tobacco company to assist in its pension planning.

Employees' working patterns may also impede management's goal of greater consistency of values and assumptions. For example, the high dependence on part time staff in retailing can result in a fragmented culture, as staff feel no commitment to their firm. Some organisations, such as ASDA, are addressing this problem by employing staff with contracts offering longer hours (Norman 1997).

Other organisations are breaking down the boundaries of subcultures. Taking employees out of their daily roles and showing them how their work relates to others in the organisation encourages them to reconsider their assumptions and values. It also helps them appreciate the corporation's intentions and recognize their importance in contributing to customer satisfaction – even if they are distant from customers. An early example of this is the British Airways programme, but a more recent case is BUPA (Mistry 1998).

The assumption that striving for a greater sense of shared values is associated with a greater likelihood of organisational success needs further consideration.

Impact of Culture on Performance

Hofstede (1980) was one of the early writers to argue the association between strong cultures and high performance and was followed by others, e.g. Peters and Waterman (1982), Kanter (1989) and Denison (1990). The rationale is that in a strong corporate culture there are consistent values and thus similar styles of

behaviour, to which new staff are inducted and which out-live changes in senior management. This leads to agreement about key objectives, albeit as Smith and Janowitz (1996) observed, it could result in imperfect alignment as different employees argue over the best tactics to meet the objectives.

The shared values engender greater motivation as staff feel proud and become committed and loyal. Understanding and conforming to the behavioural expectation from the shared values, employees need less supervision (Kotter and Heskett 1992). Strong culture companies are better able to capitalize on learning from the past, integrating successful practices into rituals and well known stories that enable staff adopt these.

A further appeal of the strong culture-performance theory is that a firm's culture provides the basis for a sustainable competitive advantage. Through working to develop a strategically appropriate culture, corporate brands are underpinned by intangible assets which competitors should find hard to emulate (e.g. Bettencourt and Brown 1997).

However, one can question the strong culture theory. Wilkins and Ouchi (1983) argue that organisations can manage themselves more efficiently by having clans. Through a socialization process, employees become integrated into clans, doing what is best for the firm by drawing on a general paradigm. This is a master routine to overcome their limited cognitive capabilities (Schwenk 1988) which provides simplification categorizations, processing procedures and examples of good solutions. However, the assumption of a shared paradigm is questionable since while managers share some aspects of their firm's paradigm, there are also idiosyncratic aspects (e.g. de Chernatony, Daniels and Johnson 1993; Reger and Huff 1993). As employees scan their environment to appreciate their corporation's paradigm, their perceptual processes focus attention on particular pieces of information, at the expense of others. Their interpretations and memory retention also vary and thus different conceptualizations of the corporation's paradigm may arise.

Another problem is the differing interpretations of "strength of culture". For example Schein (1984) regarded this as stability and intensity, Deal and Kennedy (1982) talked about coherence, while Gordon and DiTomaso (1992) interpreted it as consistency. The literature about strong culture-performance is often anecdotal and the few empirical studies that have been undertaken suffer from methodological weaknesses (Legge 1995; Brown 1995).

Of particular relevance to brand management teams is the research by Kotter and Heskett (1992). Adopting a more robust approach (albeit subject to the limitation that interviews were not with the firms' staff, but competitors' managers and analysts) they found a weak positive association between culture strength and corporate performance. They were critical of the strong culture theory, since if everyone in a firm adheres to the same but inappropriate values, everyone is following the same path to disaster. Instead, better performance is more likely when a firm has a strong culture which is:

- appropriate for its environment;

- adaptable as the environment changes;
- respects leadership at all levels;
- attentive to satisfying the needs of staff, customers and stakeholders

This work needs validating (albeit Gordon and DiTomaso (1992) also showed empirical support for the importance of cultural adaptability and performance), yet has implications for managing corporate brands.

Managers need to agree what are their few core values that should be timeless and which less central values should adapt to changing situations. For example, one of Hewlett Packard's timeless values is serving customers well. One of its less central values was encouraging staff development through internal promotion. As they moved from the instruments to the computer market they found that to best serve customers' needs they required staff who were knowledgeable about this market. To remain true to their core value they changed this less central value and recruited senior people externally (Kotter and Heskett 1992). The recent corporate redesign of BA's tail fins is visible manifestation of how the core value, striving to deliver excellent customer service has remained, but the diversity of designs reflects the new value of encouraging innovation amongst staff, who have attended training sessions to appreciate how to more flexibly meet different customers' needs.

Another implication for managing corporate brands is that the shared culture needs to recognize that any brand decisions must balance the needs of customers with staff and shareholders. This concurs with Doyle's (1992) finding that the long run success of firms depends on satisfying a coalition of stakeholders, not just one party. Richard Branson publicly declared Virgin's adherence to this, stating "We give top priorities to the interests of our staff; second priority to those of our customers; third to our shareholders Working backwards, the interests of our shareholders depend on high levels of customer satisfaction which depends on happy staff who are proud of the company they work for" (Macrae 1996b, p232).

Brand Management as Identity Management

While not negating the importance of brand image, a central theme of this paper is that more emphasis needs placing on brand identity than has historically been the case when managing brands. Drawing on the International Corporate Identity Group (van Riel and Balmer 1997) identity is about the ethos, aims and values that present a sense of individuality differentiating the brand, i.e. firm centered, while image is a holistic impression of the relative position of a brand among its perceived competitors (Poiesz 1989), i.e. customer centered.

There are several helpful models that enable managers better appreciate their corporate identity (e.g. Balmer and Stotvig 1997; van Riel 1995; Ind 1997). A particularly insightful brand-based view of identity was presented by Kapferer (1997). His hexagonal identity prism model is a powerful tool to understand the essential difference between a brand and its competitors and is based on six central components: physique, personality, culture, relationship, reflection and

self image. However in view of the previous discussion, it is contended that adaptations be made, resulting in the model portrayed in figure 1. This model conceptualises the brand's identity in terms of its vision and culture, which drive its desired positioning, personality and the subsequent relationships, all of which are then presented to reflect stakeholders' actual and aspirational self-images. The rationale for this internally focused model of brand essence is next addressed.

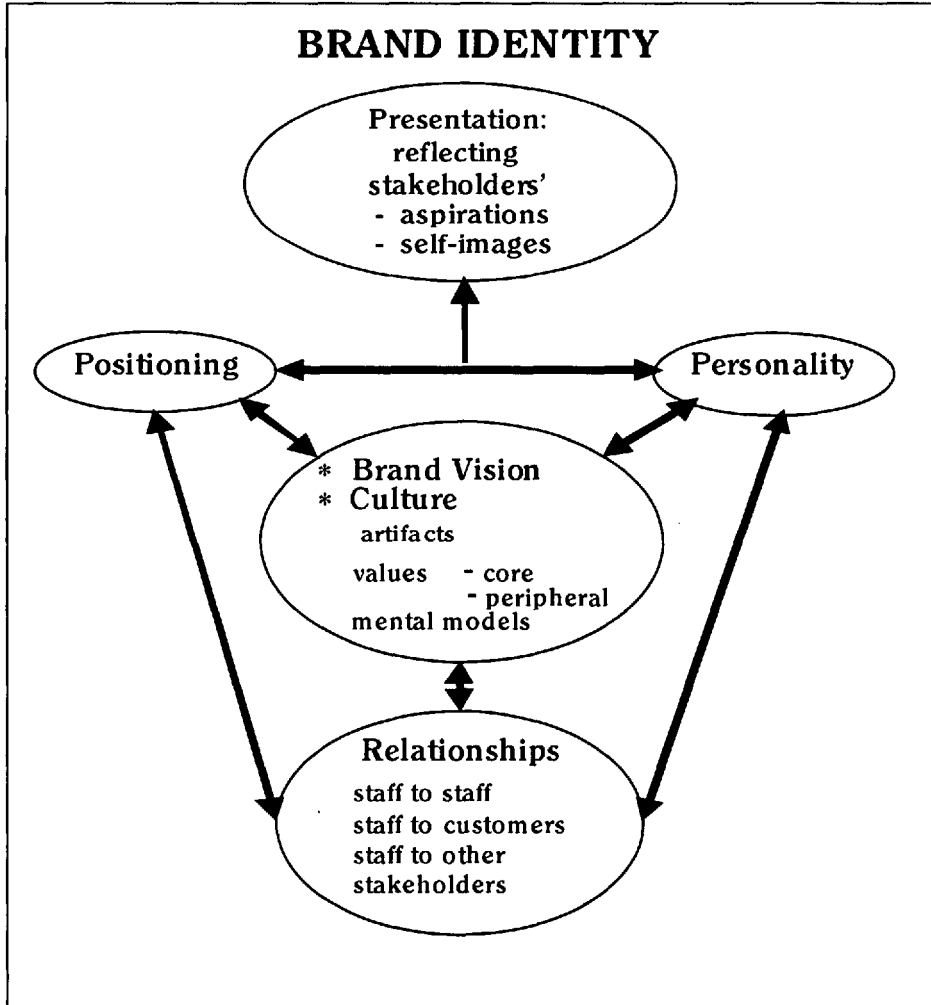


Figure 1. The Components of Brand Identity

The Brand's Vision

To thrive a brand needs a clear vision giving a well-defined sense of direction. Building on Collins and Poras (1996), managers need to envisage the brand's environment at least five years ahead, i.e. outside the time period appropriate for incremental projections, and consider how the brand is going to make this futuristic world better. This exercise is best undertaken by an independent

person collating the brand team's individual views on these two issues and then convening a workshop to present and debate them to reach a consensus.

The Brand's Culture

To develop, or refine a strategy appropriate for such a vision, the next step is to audit the brand's culture. Drawing on Schein (1984), this can be appreciated in terms of the visible artifacts, employees' and managers' values and the mental models of those involved in brand building activities. It is important to understand which values have remained unchanged over time i.e. the core values, and which have changed, i.e. the peripheral, almost fashion like, values (c.f. Kotter and Heskett 1992). While Schein refers to "basic assumptions", this is akin to Wilkins and Ouchi's (1983) "paradigm", Spender's (1989) "recipe" and the more recent literature on "cognitive maps/mental models" (Fiol and Huff 1992; Huff 1997).

This audit shows the suitability of the organisation's culture to help achieve the brand vision, through appreciating the gaps between desired and current components of culture. Drawing on the earlier points, the model encourages managers to assess the extent to which employees share similar values and also evaluate whether the culture components support each other. One way to establish the congruence of perceptions about core values is to draw on the procedure suggested by van Rekom (1997). This produces a hierarchical value map for all staff, by asking each employee to focus on their brand building activity and continually ask why it is important to the brand. The group's map is drawn by linking commonly mentioned concepts. In a shared values culture there should be frequent linkages between concepts, which in turn should lead to a greater likelihood of commitment behind the brand (Finegan and Theriault 1997; Meglino, Ravlin and Adkins 1989).

In view of the earlier section on the differentiation paradigm of corporate culture, there may be differences between the values staff hold. Workshops should then be held, explaining to staff the differences in values, showing how a cluster of desired values should result in superior brand performance, then seeking their ideas and involvement in moving to these new values. It would be inappropriate for management to adopt an authoritarian style, insisting that staff adopt the new values.

Surfacing people's mental models may provide insight about why a brand is under performing. As Bettis and Prahalad (1995) argued, managers' "dominant logic", or shared mental models, helps them cope with data overload, by focusing only on factors deemed relevant by their mental models. This filtered data becomes incorporated into brand plans. However, through this filtering and self-reinforcing behaviour, managers play down external drivers for change and in a self-deceiving cycle, performance gradually falls until a crisis forces the shared mental model to be rejected. Using an independent external organisation to surface the shared mental models and reviewing these models' appropriateness, managers can appreciate which erroneous assumptions to forget and which new ones to learn. The ultimate in challenging managers' shared mental models is

the annual client survey for Nicholson McBride, who commission a competitor to undertake this (Nicholson 1997).

The Brand's Positioning

The next stage is to consider the intended positioning's suitability against the vision and core values. This coherence check may indicate alternative actions. Kapferer (1997) does not talk about positioning, but rather "physique", i.e. the brand's physical qualities, albeit he alludes to the link between physique and personality. The model in figure 1 overtly talks about positioning, since from the brand's core values, according to means-end theory (Gutman 1982), there should be a particular set of functionally distinct capabilities that distinguishes a brand. This positioning will be reinforced through artefacts, which like Kapferer's physique, give stakeholders cues about the brand's performance characteristics. The brand's emotional values feature predominantly in the personality component of identity, which is covered in the next section.

The strength of Kapferer's (1997) argument, that this new model adheres to, is that brand identity is a richer construct to understand and build brands, than just focusing on positioning. An alternative way to develop a brand positioning is to go beyond the four issues Kapferer raises and adopt the more strategic six dimensions of Hooley, Broderick and Möller (1998), broadening the debate to become company wide. However, in so doing, the scope for misinterpretation and therefore inappropriate implementation increases. It is wrong to assume that all staff will have the same mental models about brand positioning. For example, Reger's (1990) interviews amongst managers in the same banking market showed only two positioning dimensions were common to 80% of managers and all used at least one idiosyncratic dimension to interpret competing brands' positionings. It is important to appreciate how each member of the brand's team assesses its positioning. An easy to administer and analyse procedure is the card sort technique (de Chernatony, Daniels and Johnson 1994). Once administered, each person should be shown their positioning map, comparing them against the desired map to help them understand how their views differ and the need for change.

The Brand's Personality

The firm's core values not only influence the brand's functional domain, but also it's personality. Just as positioning is a shorthand to help stakeholder groups appreciate what the brand can do for them, personality also helps reduce information search and processing, by quickly recognizing the brand's values through the personality metaphor (Aaker 1997). The challenge is to blend the personality presented through the media, with supporting congruent staff behaviour.

A link managers sometimes overlook is that between the brand's positioning and personality. The two interact as shown in figure 1. For example, in a recent study, a leading-edge brand consultant remarked "If you do a focus group amongst housewives on detergents, they will describe the Ariel woman and

contrast her to the Persil mum. Now where are they getting that from? They're not getting it from the advertising. They're getting it from the functional delivery' (de Chernatony and Dall'Omo Riley 1997). Another coherence check is therefore needed, not just between the corporation's values and the planned personality, but also between the positioning and its implications for personality.

The Brand's Relationship

Once the brand's personality has been defined, then as with all animate forms, a relationship evolves, defined by the values inherent in the brand's personality (Fournier 1998). Through several interactions, particular types of relationships evolve, enabling both parties to understand each other better. A limitation with brand image studies is they focus on the relationship from customer to brand (Blackston 1992), assuming the brand to be passive. However in the model in figure 1, the brand, through the staff, is an active participant in any relationship. Managers need to work with staff to enable them to recognise, from their core values, what types of relationships are appropriate between employees and other employees, between employees and customers and between employees and other stakeholders. Various ways of characterising relationships can be found in the business to business literature (eg Ford et al 1998; Wilson 1995) and the consumer literature (eg Fournier 1998). What is important is regularly assessing the relationships, since these change over time, and staff should be involved in evaluating how well their relationships reinforce the brand's values, personality and positioning.

The Brand's Presentation

Having maintained a dialogue with staff to develop a unified identity, the final part is identifying presentation styles. The first aspect involves considering how the brand's identity can be presented to appeal to stakeholders' aspired characteristics (cf Kapferer's (1997) reflections). The challenge is that different stakeholder groups have different points of contact with the organisation and as such there is potential for conflicting messages. Staff from all departments need to identify their stakeholders and appreciate how they evaluate and select brands. By considering the signals emitted during these processes, discrepant cues can be identified and a more coherent style of presentation devised.

The second aspect revolves around reflecting the internal self-images of the brand's stakeholders. To enable the brand to connect with stakeholders, it needs to resonate with their sense of self (Belk 1988; Hogg and Mitchell 1996) and ensure they feel comfortable with the brand in a variety of situations (Lee 1990; Sirgy 1982). Brands are valued for their symbolic meanings, helping consumers understand and express aspects of their self to others (McCracken 1993). The symbolic meaning of a brand is not only driven by advertising, but also emerges through customers interacting with staff and other brand users. Without concern for employees' contributions to the brand's self-image presentation styles, there may be incongruity between the desired symbolic meanings portrayed in the advertising and employees' behaviour. An example of reducing

such incongruity for the local community stakeholder group is seen by some organisations encouraging staff to become involved in charitable activities, for example Woolworth's employees raised £0.1m in 1997 for Whizz Kidz charity.

Brand Building as Gap Reduction

From figure 1, gaps can be identified in the brand building process where employees' perceptions, values and behaviours may run contrary to the desired brand intentions. By addressing the elements in figure 1, managers can work with staff, using participative workshops, to seek their ideas and involvement in change programmes to reduce gaps. However, sight must not be lost of the importance of external stakeholder groups, since ultimately they decide the fate of brands.

Under the traditional view of brand management, when the gap between a brand's identity and its image become noticeable, this acts as a trigger for change (Dutton and Dukerich 1991; Marziliano 1997). However, using image as an indicator for change is problematic since this focuses attention on the latest perceptions and fluctuates over short periods of time. By contrast, reputation relates to perceptions about a brand over time (Fombrun and Van Riel 1997) and is more stable. Therefore, by incorporating an externally oriented measure, i.e. brand reputation, with the internal components involved in brand building, i.e. brand identity, we have, as figure 2 shows, a mechanism to facilitate a balanced approach to brand building. By evaluating the gap between the brand's identity and its reputation, managers can fine tune their strategies to ensure a better match between identity and reputation.

There are several advantages of incorporating reputation, rather than image, into this model. Numerous stakeholder groups are interested in a firm's brand, rather than just consumers, and reputation portrays the external assessment amongst multiple stakeholders. In forming brand perceptions, people draw on many sources at different points in time, resulting in a reputation (Rindova 1997). Fombrun and Rindova (1996) crisply clarify this through their definition of corporate reputation which can be adapted for brands as "A collective representation of a brand's past actions and results that describes the brand's ability to deliver valued outcomes to multiple stakeholders". Brands strive to ensure consistency over time, yet if they fail to respond to worsening internal misalignments amongst employees, while making stretching external claims, their reputations will fall (Herbig and Milewicz 1995).

CEOs regard reputation as a particularly important intangible asset which provides the opportunity for a sustained positioning advantage (Hall 1992). It encourages greater confidence in stakeholders' anticipations about future outcomes (Weigelt and Comerer 1988) and can be a key influencer in choosing between apparently similar brands (Dowling 1994). Furthermore, favourable reputations are more likely to be associated with superior performance (Fombrun and Shanley 1990; Roberts and Dowling 1997; Fombrun 1996).

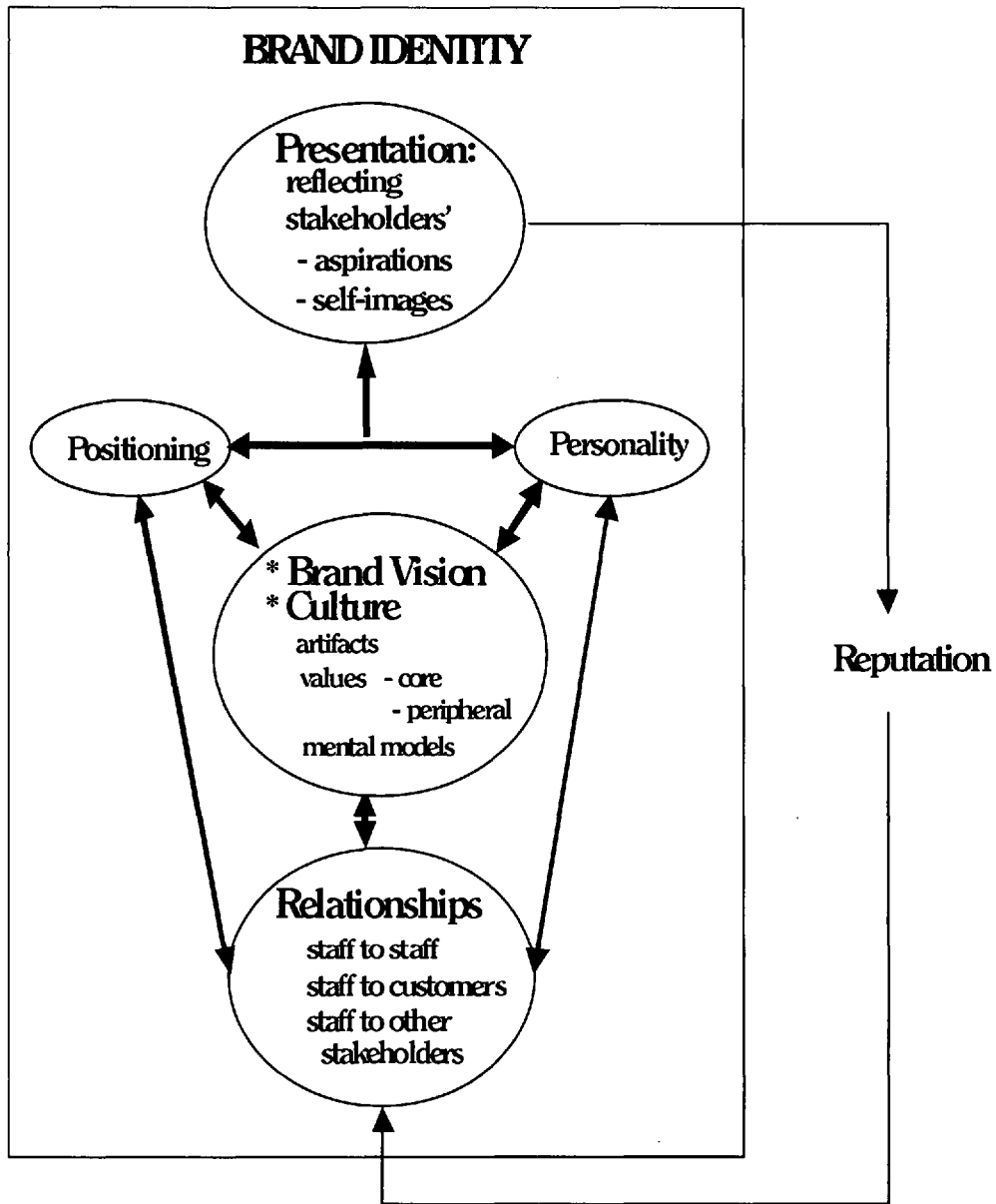


Figure 2. A Process for Managing Brands

Monitoring a brand's reputation and comparing this against the brand's identity provides insights about the urgency and direction for change. The types of changes needed can be appreciated when the differences between identity and reputation are shown for each stakeholder group separately and when they are also benchmarked against key competitors' reputations. Some questions managers and their staff should address include:

- Is the desired identity recognised by all stakeholder groups and appreciated as being distinctively superior to competition?
- Of the few critical aspects of brand identity, how consistent are the matches between identity and reputation for each stakeholder group?
- For each stakeholder group, what actions do people in all departments need to take to strengthen the identity-reputation congruity?
- Are there particular reputation problems with some stakeholder groups resulting from a lack of awareness, or evaluation skills, that need a closer relationship?
- Are staff and managers aware of the way some stakeholder groups interact with others to refract the signals staff emit? What actions are needed to minimise this refraction effect, if detrimental?
- Which aspects of the brand identity need changing and will this have an adverse impact on other identity components?
- What systems are needed to measure the impact of brand identity changes on both brand reputation and performance?

Conclusions

The literature about building and sustaining brands has placed significant emphasis on the interactions between consumers and brands. This paper seeks to redress the balance. For too long the importance of staff as brand builders has not been sufficiently considered. By bringing them into the brand building process, making them aware of their roles in delivering their brand's identity then alerting them to their brand's reputation, and therefore differences, they can participate in the process of considering how to change to better deliver the desired identity.

In view of this special edition exploring the notion of brand reality, the arguments in this paper support the significant contribution brand reality can make to brand building. Brands are clusters of values and, particularly for corporate brands, these values emanate from people inside the firm (as well as from corporate communication programmes). In view of the key role staff play in shaping a brand's values, more emphasis needs placing on internal aspects of branding. This paper advocates a more effective approach to branding through a more open style with employees, to enlist their participation and commitment to delivering a coherent set of values.

If firms are to capitalise on brand reality, this paper proposes a wider remit to brand management, starting with the inclusion of the HRM Director in the brand's team. Staff recruitment policies would benefit from basing selection criteria on the congruency of applicants' values with the brand's desired values. Training programmes for all employees should not just be about skills and knowledge development, but also about individuals' roles in brand building. Creative approaches are needed for these training programmes to encourage staff to consider how they can change to reinforce a particular cluster of values and style of behaviour. New ways of communicating information about branding

issues are needed, so all staff can relate to these in their specific roles and better contribute. Only when staff understand the brand vision and are committed, proud and able to contribute, should advertising claims then be made.

Values are part of the broader concept of culture and this paper further reinforces the importance of brand reality by considering how culture can affect brand performance. It has argued that culture is not something management can rigidly control, but rather is a context within which employees interpret a brand's identity. From the differentiation paradigm of culture, it is likely that there will be several sub-cultures in a firm. Based on the brand identity model in figure 1, managers need to assess the extent to which these sub-cultures support the desired brand. These findings need communicating to the different groups of employees and, in a participative style, their commitment sought to stimulate ideas about adaptations to better support the desired brand identity.

The concept of brand image has not been negated, rather it has been argued that brand reputation is a more powerful concept. It assesses perceptions across many stakeholder groups, does not just focus on the most recent impression and is a predictor for stakeholders of future outcomes. The strength of brand reality is it alerts managers to internal considerations, and when they assess the congruency between the brand's identity and its reputation, they then have a balanced approach to brand building as they strive to reduce any gaps.

The model in this paper is grounded in the literature and while it has also evolved from brand strategy workshops with managers, has not been subjected to empirical testing. A research programme has started to test sections of this model and it is planned to report the findings in the future.

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